technological sophistication was minimal, they introduced the fundamental principles of remote-controlled flight, forming the foundation for subsequent UAV advancements.

- *Manual control*: First-generation drones were fully operated through basic radio control systems, requiring constant human input. The operator, using a handheld transmitter, controlled the aircraft's altitude, direction, and speed without any assistance from stabilization or feedback systems. This mode of operation demanded significant skill and concentration, as the aircraft's flight stability depended entirely on human precision. For example, the *Aerial Target (1916)*, an early British UAV prototype, was manually guided through simple radio commands, demonstrating the earliest form of remote-controlled flight. ••
- *Limited range and endurance*: These drones had a very limited operational range and flight endurance due to weak radio transmission power and small onboard fuel reserves. They could only be operated within a direct line of sight, typically over short distances, as any signal loss would immediately result in loss of control. Flight durations rarely exceeded a few minutes, which restricted their utility to experimental or short training missions. •• ••
- *Fixed-wing design*: Structurally, most first-generation drones featured a fixed-wing airframe, closely resembling miniature aircraft. Their aerodynamic design was functional rather than optimized for performance, focusing primarily on maintaining lift and basic maneuverability. The wings were non-adjustable, and aerodynamic control was achieved through rudimentary mechanical linkages connected to the control surfaces. •• ••